Let My People Go

By James Weldon Johnson

INTRODUCTION

Estimates suggest that almost 900 million people have died in religious conflicts throughout history, with many more suffering a vast array of abuses in the name of God.

In the Book of Exodus, God tells Moses to go to Pharaoh, to demand: "Let my people go." The plea is insufficient. Pharaoh is an evil man, wielding murderous power. In the end, however, neither his wickedness nor his troops are any match for the rower of God. Pharaoh is defeated, at a terrible human price, and peace comes to the Children of Israel.

Today, our Armed Forces battle in Iraq, because words failed to stop Saddam Hussein from his own mad murderousness. Let us pray that, when all is done, we will view the invasion of Iraq as an act of peace not war. Let My People Go by James Weldon Johnson.

And God called Moses from the burning bush,

He called in a still, small voice,

And he said: Moses - Moses

And Moses listened,

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And he answered and said:

Lord, here am I.

And the voice in the bush said: Moses,

Draw not nigh, take off your shoes,

For you're standing on holy ground.

And Moses stopped where he stood,

And Moses took off his shoes,

And Moses looked at the burning bush,

And he heard the voice,

But he saw no man.

Then God again spoke to Moses,

And he spoke in a voice of thunder:

I am the Lord God Almighty,

I am the God of thy fathers,

I am the God of Abraham,

Of Isaac and of Jacob.

And Moses hid his face.

And God said to Moses:

I've seen the awful suffering

Of my people down in Egypt.

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I've watched their hard oppressors,
Their overseers and drivers;
The groans of my people have filled my ears
And I can't stand it no longer;
So I'm come down to deliver them
Out of the land of Egypt,
And I will bring them out of that land
Into the land of Canaan;
Therefore, Moses, go down,
Go down into Egypt,
And tell Old Pharaoh
To let my people go.
And Moses said: Lord, who am I
To make a speech before Pharaoh?
For, Lord, you know I'm slow of tongue.
But God said: I will be thy mouth and
I will be thy tongue;
Therefore, Moses, go down,
Go down yonder into Egypt land,

And tell Old Pharaoh

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To let my people go.
And Moses with his rod in hand
Went down and said to Pharaoh:
Thus saith the Lord God of Israel,
Let my people go.
And Pharaoh looked at Moses,
He stopped still and looked at Moses
And he said to Moses: Who is this Lord?
I know all the gods of Egypt,
But I know no God of Israel
So go back, Moses, and tell your God,
I will not let this people go.
Poor Old Pharaoh,
He knows all the knowledge of Egypt,
Yet never knew
He never knew
The one and the living God.
Poor Old Pharaoh,
He's got all the power of Egypt,
And he's going to try
To test his strength

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With the might of the great Jehovah,
With the might of the Lord God of Hosts,
The Lord mighty in battle.
And God, sitting high up in his heaven,
Laughed at poor Old Pharaoh.
And Pharaoh called the overseers,
And Pharaoh called the drivers,
And he said: Put heavier burdens still
On the backs of the Hebrew Children.
Then the people chode with Moses,
And they cried out: Look here, Moses,
You've been to Pharaoh, but look and see
What Pharaoh's done to us now.
And Moses was troubled in mind.
But God said: Go again, Moses,
You and your brother, Aaron,
And say once more to Pharaoh,
Thus saith the Lord God of the Hebrews,
Let my people go.
And Moses and Aaron with their rods in hand
Worked many signs and wonders.

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But Pharaoh called for his magic men,
And they worked wonders, too.
So Pharaohs' heart was hardened,
And he would not,
No, he would not
Let God's people go.
And God rained down plagues on Egypt,
Plagues of frogs and lice and locusts,
Plagues of blood and boils and darkness,
And other plagues besides.
But ev'ry time God moved the plague
Old Pharaoh's heart was hardened,
And he would not,

No, he would not
Let God's people go.
And Moses was troubled in mind.
Then the Lord said: Listen, Moses,
The God of Israel will not be mocked,
Just one more witness of my power
I'll give hard-hearted Pharaoh.

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This very night about midnight,
I'll pass over Egypt land,
In my righteous wrath will I pass over,
And smite their first-born dead.
And God that night passed over.
And a cry went up out of Egypt.
And Pharaoh rose in the middle of the night
And he sent in a hurry for Moses;
And he said: Go forth from among my people,
You and all the Hebrew Children;
Take your goods and take your flocks,
And get away from the land of Egypt.
And, right then, Moses led them out,
With all their goods and all their flocks;
And God went on before,
A guiding pillar of cloud by day,
And a pillar of fire by night.
And they journeyed on in the wilderness,
And came down to the Red Sea.

In the morning,

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Oh, in the morning,
They missed the Hebrew Children.
Four hundred years,
Four hundred years
They'd held them down in Egypt land.
Held them under the driver's lash,
Working without money and without price.
And it might have been Pharaoh's wife that said:
Pharaoh -look what you've done.
You let those Hebrew Children go,
And who's going to serve us now?
Who's going to make our bricks and mortar?
Who's going to plant and plow our corn?
Who's going to get up in the chill of the morning?
And who's going to work in the blazing sun?
Pharaoh, tell me that!
And Pharaoh called his generals,
And the generals called the captains,
And the captains called the soldiers.
And they hitched up all the chariots,
Six hundred chosen chariots of war,

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And twenty-four hundred horses.
And the chariots all were full of men,
With swords and shields
And shiny spears
And battle bows and arrows.
And Pharaoh and his army
Pursued the Hebrew Children
To the edge of the Red Sea.

Now, the Children of Israel, looking back,
Saw Pharaoh's army coming.
And the rumble of the chariots was like a thunder storm,
And the whirring of the wheels was like a rushing wind,
And the dust from the horses made a cloud that darked the day,
And the glittering of the spears was like lightnings in the night.
And the Children of Israel all lost faith,
The children of Israel all lost hope;
Deep Red Sea in front of them

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And Pharaoh's host behind.
And they mumbled and grumbled among themselves:
Were there no graves in Egypt?
And they wailed aloud to Moses and said:
Slavery in Egypt was better than to come
To die here in this wilderness.
But Moses said:
Stand still! Stand still I
And see the Lord's salvation.
For the Lord God of Israel
Will not forsake his people.
The Lord will break the chariots,
The Lord will break the horsemen,
He'll break great Egypt's sword and shield,
The battle bows and arrows;
This day he'll make proud Pharaoh know
Who is the God of Israel.

And Moses lifted up his rod
Over the Red Sea
And God with a blast of his nostrils

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Blew the waters apart,

And the waves rolled back and stood up in a pile,

And left a path through the middle of the sea

Dry as the sands of the desert.

And the Children of Israel all crossed over

On to the other side.

When Pharaoh saw them crossing dry,

He dashed on in behind them

Old Pharaoh got about half way cross,

And God unlashed the waters,

And the waves rushed back together,

And Pharaoh and all his army got lost,

And all his host got drownded.

And Moses sang and Miriam danced,

And the people shouted for joy,

And God led the Hebrew Children on

Till they reached the promised land.

Listen 1- Listen 1

All you sons of Pharaoh.

Who do you think can hold God's people

When the Lord God himself has said,

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Let my people go?

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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